

# Promoting Trust and Professionalism in an Era of Digital Health and (mis)Information

American Board of Medical Specialties Conference

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# Panelists

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*Nothing to disclose*

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*Nothing to disclose*

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*Nothing to disclose*

# Learning Objectives

- Examine how digitally mediated care and technology integration are reshaping foundations of the patient–physician relationship.
- Explain how health misinformation can undermine professional authority, shared decision-making, and trust.
- Describe how board certification is valued by patients and can serve as a foundation for promoting trust and professionalism in a digital and information-rich healthcare environment.

# Defining Digital Health

Framing the landscape · FDA, WHO, and AMA terminology

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Digital health is the use of digital and information technologies to support and improve health and health care delivery — encompassing **telehealth and telemedicine, mobile health, wearable devices, electronic health records, AI-powered diagnostics, and remote monitoring systems**. These technologies are reshaping how care is delivered and how trust between patients and providers is established and maintained.

Source: FDA Center for Devices and Radiological Health; WHO Global Strategy on Digital Health 2020–2025; AMA Digital Medicine Resources; Center for Connected Medicine Digital Health Survey

# A Parallel Challenge – Health Misinformation

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The same digital infrastructure that expands care access also amplifies false health claims. WHO declared a parallel "infodemic" alongside COVID-19 in 2020: health misinformation spreads up to 6× faster than accurate content online, complicating patient decision-making and underscoring the need for verified, credentialed care sources.

[World Health Organization](#). (2020). *Novel Coronavirus (2019-nCoV): Situation report - 13*. [World Health Organization](#).

# Where Americans Get Health Information

And who they trust — Pew Research Center, April 2026 (n=5,111 U.S. adults)

| SOURCE                               | USE AT LEAST SOMETIMES | RATE HIGHLY ACCURATE |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------|----------------------|
| Healthcare providers                 | 85%                    | 65%                  |
| Health websites (WebMD, Mayo Clinic) | 60%                    | 48%                  |
| People with similar health issues    | 66%                    | —                    |
| News organizations                   | 46%                    | —                    |
| Government health agencies           | 45%                    | —                    |
| Social media                         | 36%                    | 7%                   |
| AI chatbots                          | 22%                    | —                    |

## PATIENT CHALLENGES

76%

encounter conflicting health info at least sometimes

50%

struggle to judge health information accuracy

54%

unsure which conflicting source to trust

73%

consult three or more sources

Source: Pew Research Center, "Where Do Americans Get Health Information, and What Do They Trust?" (April 2026)

# Defining the Problem

## MISINFORMATION

*False or inaccurate information shared without intent to deceive.*

### **Examples in healthcare:**

- Sharing outdated dosing guidelines
- Forwarding unverified "natural cures"
- Misremembering a diagnosis or test result
- Reposting a study out of context

## DISINFORMATION

*False information deliberately created and spread with intent to deceive.*

### **Examples in healthcare:**

- Fabricated research to discredit vaccines
- Industry-funded studies designed to mislead
- Coordinated conspiracy theory campaigns
- Anti-medicine disinformation networks

# Misinformation as a Clinical Crisis

Physicians Foundation Survey · 2025–2026

# 86%

of physicians say health misinformation has increased vs. five years ago — half describe the rise as significant

Physicians Foundation

# 70%

of physicians treated patients influenced by misinformation in the past year

# 50%

frequently observe treatment nonadherence directly linked to false health content

# 33%

report frequent erosion of patient-physician trust as a result of misinformation

# 26%

feel confident engaging skeptical patients — down from 37% the prior year

Top sources patients cite: social media & influencers · news & search engines (50%+) · AI chatbots (33%)

# The Scale of the Problem

*Health misinformation on social media has reached epidemic proportions*

**51%**

of vaccine-related social media posts contain misinformation

**60%**

of pandemic-related social media posts spread false information

**28.8%**

of COVID-19 posts on social media were inaccurate

**20–30%**

of YouTube health videos contain misleading or inaccurate content

# Impact on Clinicians

*Physicians Foundation National Survey of U.S. Physicians (2024)*

## FINDING 1 OF 3

86%

of physicians say medical  
misinformation has increased  
compared to 5 years ago

*"50% call it a significant increase"*

## FINDING 2 OF 3

61%

of physicians say patients  
were influenced by false health  
info in the past year

*"at least a moderate amount"*

## FINDING 3 OF 3

57%

say misinformation significantly  
impairs their ability to  
deliver quality care

*Physician–patient trust at risk*

Additional finding: 40% of physicians feel "not at all confident" patients can find evidence-based information independently

# The Economic Cost

*Misinformation carries a measurable, quantifiable price tag*

**\$2**  
**BILLION**

in avoidable hospitalizations  
from COVID-19 vaccine  
misinformation in the U.S.  
in 2021 alone

**~2.3M**

additional COVID-19 cases linked to vaccine misinformation

**66,000**

hospitalizations that could have been prevented

**45,000**

preventable deaths from misinformation-driven hesitancy

**\$50–300M**

per day in broader economic costs (productivity, mortality)

# Social Media: The Primary Vector

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*Falsehoods are 70% more likely to be shared than accurate information — spreading further, faster, deeper, and more broadly across social networks.*

MIT Media Lab, Science (2018) · Analysis of 126,000 stories shared on Twitter over 11 years

319K

Preventable COVID deaths  
(Jan 2021–Apr 2022)

*Brown Univ. School of Public Health*

16%

of parents who have delayed or skipped  
recommended vaccines)

*Kaiser Family Foundation/Washington Post Survey  
2025*

70%

more likely that a false  
headline is shared vs. true one

*MIT Media Lab, Science 2018*

# What Patients Do with Misinformation

*Downstream clinical consequences*



## Vaccine Refusal

Exposure to online misinformation significantly increases vaccine hesitancy. Over 51% of vaccine-related posts contain false claims that reach patients directly.



## Treatment Abandonment

Patients refuse antibiotics, chemotherapy, and surgical anesthesia based on conspiracy theories encountered on social media and forums.



## Delayed Care-Seeking

Misinformation leads patients to postpone evaluations, relying on online "self-diagnosis" — allowing conditions to worsen before clinical contact.



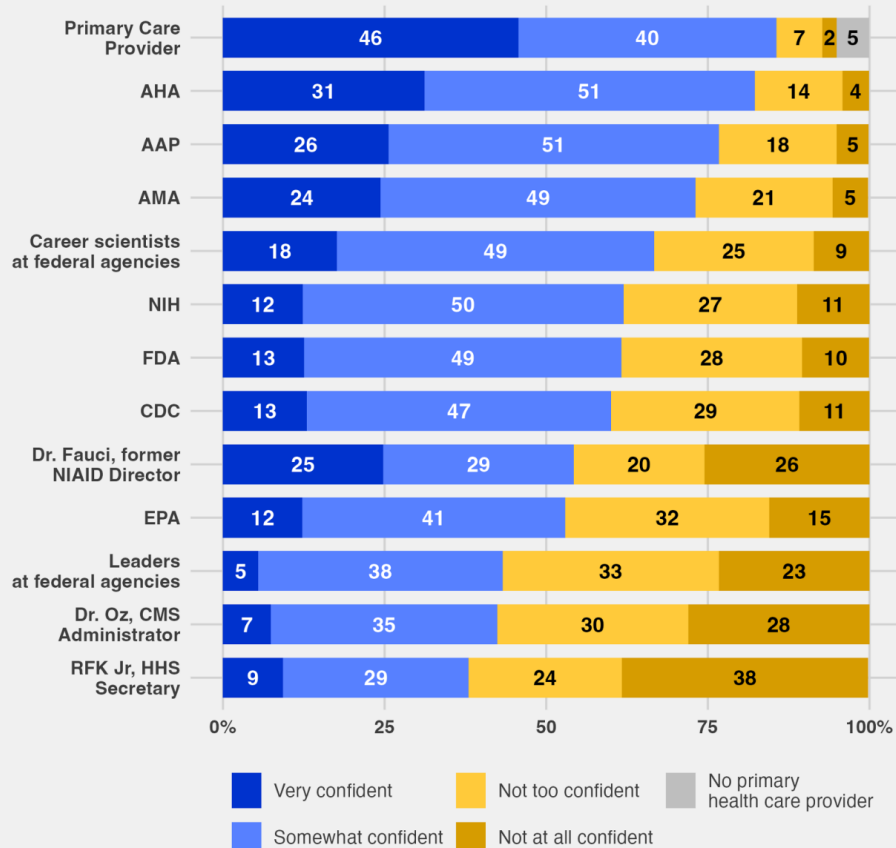
## Unproven Alternatives

Patients substitute evidence-based care with homeopathy, unregulated supplements, or social-media "cures," often without disclosing this to clinicians.

**Clinical insight:** Healthcare professionals describe patients "trusting Google more than medical information" — and report being bypassed entirely for self-diagnosis.

# Confidence in Custodians of Public Health

How confident, if at all, are you that \_\_\_\_\_ is providing\* the public with trustworthy information about matters concerning public health\*\*?



\*For Dr. Fauci, former NIAID Director, the question said 'provided' instead of 'is providing' since he is a former federal government official.

\*\*The EPA item asked about 'matters concerning the effects of climate change on public health'.

Source: Annenberg Science and Public Health (ASAPH) Survey Feb. 2026, N=1650, MOE=±3.5%

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# Board Certification as a Trust Signal

Consumer survey data · NORC at the University of Chicago for ABMS · n=1,516 · January–February 2025 · ±3.54 pp

**93%**

say board certification is  
important when choosing  
a physician

**98%**

expect physicians to stay  
current with the latest  
medical advances

**95%**

expect physicians to  
participate in ongoing  
education and testing

**84%**

would switch doctors if  
their physician did not  
maintain certification

2008

**91%**

n=1,009



2010

**91%**

n=1,006



2018

**82%**

n=1,792



2025

**93%**

n=1,516

- **90% support periodic knowledge evaluations beyond standard CME credits**
- **Over 1 million credential searches on ABMS Certification Matters in 2024 alone**